

Questions Matter

Every conversation with AI happens the same way: you ask a question, and AI gives an answer.

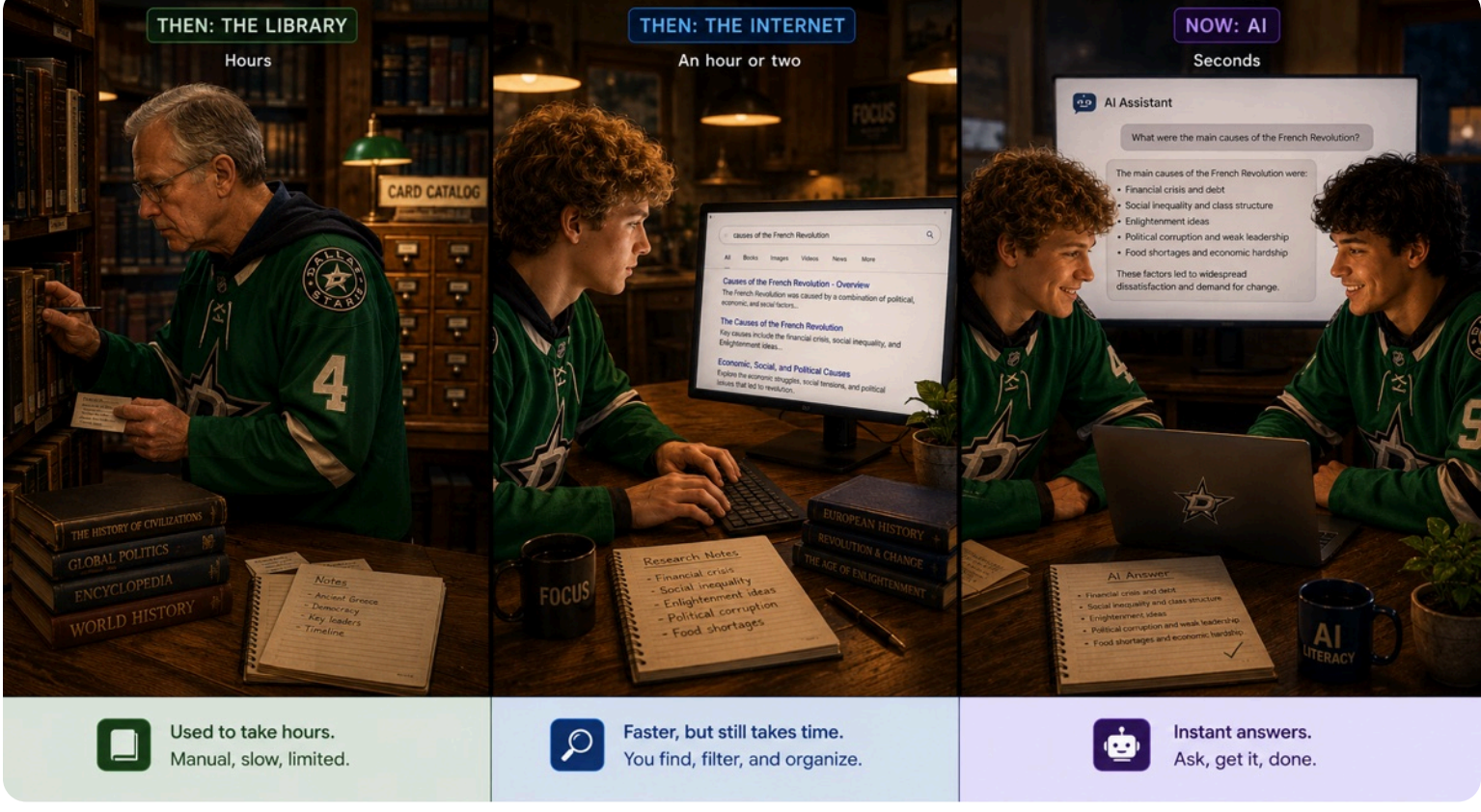
For decades, technology has been making it easier and easier to get answers. And the less time we spend chasing the answer, the more time we have for the half that’s still 100% ours: **asking the right question**.

One example makes the whole idea click. Teachers have been handing out research assignments since the dawn of school. But look at how this changed between your grandparents, your parents, and you.

How answers got cheap		
PRE-INTERNET (GRANDPARENTS)  The library 1. Get to a library and search the card catalog 2. Track down the right books and periodicals on the shelves 3. Read until you find what you need, copying notes by hand TIME TO ANSWER Half a Saturday	THE INTERNET (PARENTS)  Search 1. Run search after search, opening tab after tab 2. Judge which sites to trust and skim for the useful parts 3. Copy and paste the good pieces into a doc TIME TO ANSWER An hour or two	NOW (YOU)  AI 1. Open your favorite AI app 2. Ask 3. The answer is on your screen TIME TO ANSWER Seconds

Half a day, then an hour, now seconds. AI makes answers cheap to get. That does not make humans less valuable. **It changes where value lives.**

FINDING THE ANSWER For your grandparents, knowing how to hunt down an answer was a real skill. AI just did the hunting in seconds.	ASKING THE QUESTION AI only answered the question it was given. When anyone can get a fast answer, the edge shifts to the person who can ask the better question.
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WHAT MAKES A GOOD QUESTION?

Asking good questions is one of humanity’s oldest skills. Socrates taught by doing almost nothing but asking. The scientific method doesn’t start with an answer; it starts with a question worth testing. Einstein supposedly said that with an hour to save the world, he’d spend the first 55 minutes finding the right question.

So what separates a good question from a weak one? Four qualities, and none of them mention AI.

1  Open-Minded You haven’t picked the answer in advance. A leading question isn’t research, it’s a request for backup. BAD <i>Homework doesn’t help students learn. Can you help me prove it?</i> BETTER <i>What does the research actually say about homework and learning?</i>
2  Specific It says enough about your situation. A question without enough information returns an answer that helps with nothing. BAD <i>How do I get better at sports?</i> BETTER <i>I play basketball as a point guard. Sometimes I lose the ball against pressure. What drills fix that?</i>
3  On Target Specific is about how much your question says. On target is about asking the right thing: the problem you’re actually trying to solve. BAD <i>What energy drinks work best for staying awake in class?</i> BETTER <i>I keep falling asleep in first period no matter how interesting the class is. How do I fix my sleep schedule?</i>
4  Open-Ended A yes-or-no question ends the conversation; an open-ended one starts it. Leave room for an answer you didn’t expect. BAD <i>Should I join the debate team?</i> BETTER <i>What would joining debate add to my week, and what would I have to give up for it?</i>

Notice that AI hasn’t come up yet. These four qualities worked in Socrates’ Athens and they work in a chat window. What changed is the payoff: now that answers are instant, the quality of the question is the whole game.

A better question doesn’t make the answer automatically true. It just makes the answer more focused, more useful, and easier to check.

Answers got cheap. Questions didn’t.

Frame the problem. Ask the next better question.